

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 4

Chapter 7: The Gupta Era: An Age of Tireless Creativity

Paper 4 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	7 — The Gupta Era: An Age of Tireless Creativity
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. The classic traps are fusing Chandragupta II (Gupta) with the far earlier Chandragupta Maurya, claiming iron 'cannot rust' instead of crediting the pillar's phosphorus-rich passive layer, mis-crediting the Prayaga Prashasti to anyone but Samudragupta, treating Faxian's prosperous-city report as the whole neutral truth, and reading 'Golden Age' as social equality rather than cultural brilliance. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. Three statements are offered: (i) Chandragupta I founded the empire's greatness; (ii) Samudragupta was the son of Chandragupta I; (iii) Chandragupta II was the father of Samudragupta. Exactly one statement is false. Which is it, and why?

- (A) Statement (i), because the empire's greatness was first founded by Samudragupta
- (B) Statement (iii), because Chandragupta II was the successor who reigned after Samudragupta, not his father
- (C) Statement (ii), because Samudragupta belonged to a different dynasty from Chandragupta I
- (D) All three are false, because the three names actually refer to one ruler at different ages

2. A timeline shows Mauryas, then Kushanas, then Guptas. A student infers, 'Therefore the Guptas took power immediately after the Mauryas with no gap.' What is the precise flaw?

- (A) The Kushanas actually came before the Mauryas, so the timeline itself is wrong
- (B) The Guptas in fact preceded the Mauryas, making the whole sequence reversed

(C) The Kushana period lies between the Mauryas and the Guptas, so centuries separate the two empires rather than no gap

(D) There is no flaw, since 'after the Mauryas' must always mean immediately after

3. Which single change to the sentence 'The Gupta capital Pataliputra was also a famed Mauryan capital, proving the two dynasties were the same' makes it historically sound?

(A) Replace 'Pataliputra' with 'Kanchipuram', the city both dynasties used

(B) Replace 'proving the two dynasties were the same' with 'though the two dynasties ruled centuries apart'

(C) Replace 'Mauryan' with 'Pallava', since Pataliputra was the Pallava capital

(D) Replace 'Gupta capital' with 'Gupta seaport', since Pataliputra lay on the coast

4. The Gupta Empire is dated to roughly the 4th to 6th centuries CE. Which claim, if true, would directly contradict that dating?

(A) The Hunas pressed on the empire in the 6th century CE

(B) Chandragupta I strengthened the dynasty in the early 4th century CE

(C) Samudragupta led his conquests in the 2nd century BCE

(D) Aryabhata wrote around 500 CE during the empire's cultural peak

5. Chandragupta I is said to have married a Licchavi princess. Read together with the Guptas being a then-rising power, this marriage is best understood as:

(A) A matrimonial alliance that lent the young dynasty the prestige and allies of an established line

(B) A device for collecting the empire's yearly land tax from the Licchavis

(C) A treaty by which the Guptas surrendered their throne to the Licchavi family

(D) A purely religious ceremony with no bearing on the dynasty's standing

6. Which pairing of Gupta ruler and the achievement most strongly tied to that ruler is correct?

(A) Samudragupta — celebrated in the Prayaga Prashasti for wide conquests

(B) Chandragupta I — the rust-resistant 'Chandra' Iron Pillar of Delhi

(C) Chandragupta II — the first Gupta to assume an imperial title

(D) Kumaragupta — the Chinese Buddhist pilgrim who toured India

7. Why is crediting the conquests in the Prayaga (Allahabad) Prashasti to Chandragupta II a factual error?

(A) Both rulers are jointly named as conquerors in the same prashasti, so either is correct

(B) Chandragupta II composed the prashasti himself, so its conquests are his own

(C) The prashasti actually praises Chandragupta Maurya, so no Gupta should be credited

(D) The prashasti eulogises Samudragupta's military campaigns, while Chandragupta II was his successor known mainly for cultural splendour

8. The Prayaga Prashasti was written by Samudragupta's own court poet. A careful historian therefore concludes that the inscription is:

- (A) A useful but partial source whose praise must be cross-checked against other evidence
- (B) A neutral record whose every line can be accepted as plain unbiased fact
- (C) Entirely worthless, since court poetry can never serve as historical evidence
- (D) The work of a rival king secretly mocking Samudragupta

9. The composer of the Prayaga Prashasti was:

- (A) Kalidasa, the playwright of the Meghadutam
- (B) Aryabhata, the mathematician-astronomer
- (C) Harisena, Samudragupta's court poet
- (D) Faxian, the visiting Chinese pilgrim

10. Samudragupta is remembered above all as a warrior who expanded the empire. Which inference about the wider record best follows from this?

- (A) The empire he passed on was larger than the one he inherited, expanded by conquest
- (B) He never once waged war, which is why his fame rests on peace
- (C) He composed the Aryabhatiya, proving his fame was scientific not military
- (D) He was a foreign invader from Central Asia who briefly held the north

11. Why can the 'Chandra' inscription on the Delhi Iron Pillar not belong to Chandragupta Maurya, despite the shared name element 'Chandra'?

- (A) Chandragupta Maurya never used the element 'Chandra' in any form
- (B) Chandragupta Maurya ruled centuries earlier, while the pillar's Gupta-period style and 'Chandra' fit Chandragupta II
- (C) The Mauryas worked only in gold and could not have raised an iron pillar
- (D) Both kings carried the title Vikramaditya, so the pillar must mean the Delhi ruler

12. A guidebook says, 'The Iron Pillar has never rusted because iron simply cannot rust.' What is the correct objection?

- (A) The pillar is in fact made of bronze, not iron at all
- (B) Ordinary iron does rust; the pillar endures because its phosphorus-rich iron forms a thin protective film that seals out air and moisture
- (C) The pillar is repainted with a rust-proof coating every year
- (D) The pillar stands in a sheltered spot where rain never reaches it

13. What does the long survival of the rust-resistant Iron Pillar most directly reveal about the Gupta age?

- (A) The Guptas imported all their finished metal ready-made from Rome
- (B) Its metalworkers possessed advanced iron-making skill capable of producing corrosion-resistant iron

- (C) The Guptas knew how to work no metal except gold
- (D) Ancient Indians could not yet work iron at any useful scale

14. Chandragupta II's defeat of the Shakas (Western Kshatrapas) brought the empire which practical gain?

- (A) Control of the western regions and their ports, extending Gupta reach toward the Arabian Sea trade
- (B) The conquest of China and an overland route to the Pacific
- (C) The discovery of zero, which the defeated Shakas had hidden
- (D) The end of the Mauryan dynasty, which the Shakas had protected

15. The title 'Vikramaditya' (vikrama + aditya), borne by Chandragupta II, means:

- (A) 'Great king of kings'
- (B) 'Universal ruler over all lesser kings'
- (C) 'Sun of Valour'
- (D) 'Servant of the gods'

16. The clustering of Kalidasa, Aryabhata and Varahamihira at or near Chandragupta II's court is best explained by the ruler acting as:

- (A) A regent ruling temporarily on behalf of a child-king
- (B) A foreign conqueror who suppressed all learning
- (C) A wandering pilgrim who travelled abroad seeking texts
- (D) A patron who supported and encouraged poets, scientists and scholars

17. Which set of achievements is correctly tied to Chandragupta II's reign?

- (A) The Prayaga Prashasti and a conquest-heavy warrior reign
- (B) The very first founding of the Gupta empire
- (C) The Huna invasions that finally ended the dynasty
- (D) The flowering of Kalidasa's poetry and the linkage of the 'Chandra' Iron Pillar to his reign

18. Why does the grand title 'Maharajadhiraja' tell us something different about Gupta politics than the plain title 'raja'?

- (A) It claims supremacy over other kings, implying lesser kings stood beneath the Gupta ruler
- (B) It marks the ruler as only a village headman with no kingdom
- (C) It shows the ruler had surrendered all power to a council
- (D) It signals that the ruler served as a temple priest rather than a king

19. The title 'Chakravartin' claimed by a powerful ruler carried the idea of:

- (A) A temple priest performing daily worship for the king
- (B) A universal sovereign whose authority extended over all lesser kings
- (C) A village headman responsible only for local taxes
- (D) A foreign ambassador sent to negotiate trade treaties

20. A coin shows a Gupta king as an archer, and an inscription calls him 'Maharajadhiraja'. Read together, the safest conclusion about how he wished to appear is:

- (A) A humble servant of the villagers with no claim to power
- (B) A pilgrim who had given up the throne to seek holy places
- (C) A foreign trader who had come to India to buy gold
- (D) A mighty warrior and supreme overlord, projecting both martial strength and paramount status

21. Why is engraving land grants on copper plates rather than perishable material historically revealing about Gupta governance?

- (A) It shows the Guptas ruled entirely by word of mouth with no records
- (B) It proves all land in the empire was owned directly by foreign kings
- (C) It shows the Guptas used coins instead of any written documents
- (D) It shows the state kept durable written records of land rights, evidence of an organised, documented administration

22. An 'agrahara' was a village or piece of land, often tax-free, granted by a king mainly to brahmins or temples. Repeated over generations, such grants would tend to:

- (A) Permanently swell the treasury, since tax-free land paid double the usual taxes
- (B) Force the king to abolish his army, as grant-holders supplied all soldiers
- (C) Shrink the king's tax revenue and pass local authority to grant-holders, weakening direct royal control
- (D) End the empire's overseas trade by binding all merchants to temple land

23. Compared with the Mauryan ideal of governing every region directly, the Gupta state is best described as relying more on:

- (A) An elected national assembly that chose the emperor every year
- (B) Foreign Roman administrators sent to run every Gupta province
- (C) Complete withdrawal of the king from all governance
- (D) Allied and subordinate kings together with land grants, ruling the north and centre directly but the rest more loosely

24. Why is it inaccurate to say 'the Guptas ruled the whole subcontinent directly, just as the Mauryas had'?

- (A) Because the Guptas in fact controlled only the single city of Pataliputra
- (B) Because the Guptas were a loose alliance with no central ruler at all
- (C) They directly governed mainly the north and centre and relied on grants and allied kings elsewhere, with the south and northeast under their own rulers
- (D) Because the Guptas held no territory and existed only as a band of traders

25. Why were the Guptas' grand titles and elaborate administration developed together?

- (A) To project the emperor's supreme authority and to organise governance across a large realm
- (B) To disguise the fact that the Guptas commanded no army at all
- (C) To prove publicly that the Gupta rulers were foreigners
- (D) To make royal officials unnecessary and abolish their posts

26. Prabhavati Gupta, who governed as regent after her husband's death and kept ties between kingdoms, married into which contemporary dynasty?

- (A) The Hunas, the Central Asian group that later invaded the empire
- (B) The Pallavas, the southern dynasty of Kanchipuram
- (C) The Vakatakas, a ruling house allied to the Guptas through that marriage
- (D) The Licchavis, whom Chandragupta I had married into earlier

27. A 'regent' is best defined as someone who:

- (A) Travels to holy places to gather religious merit
- (B) Governs a kingdom temporarily on behalf of a monarch unable to rule, often a child
- (C) Composes formal praise-poems celebrating a king
- (D) Studies the motions of the stars and planets

28. Prabhavati Gupta's career as regent and diplomat is best taken as evidence that, in this period, royal women:

- (A) Were never permitted any role whatsoever in governance
- (B) Were allowed to rule only if they came from foreign dynasties
- (C) Personally led the empire's armies into every major battle
- (D) Could at times wield real political power

29. Faxian, whose account describes Gupta society, is best identified as:

- (A) Samudragupta's court poet who composed the Prayaga Prashasti
- (B) A Roman trader who recorded the empire's ports and goods
- (C) A Chinese Buddhist pilgrim who travelled across India observing society along the way
- (D) A Huna general who left an account of his invasion of the north

30. Faxian described Gupta cities as prosperous and full of charitable rest-houses. Why does a careful historian treat this as only part of the picture?

- (A) He wrote the account many centuries after the Gupta age, so none of it is reliable
- (B) He recorded mainly the well-off urban scenes and also noted the chandalas forced to live apart, so his account must be cross-checked
- (C) He never actually visited India and copied his report from Roman traders
- (D) He was a paid Gupta court official whose every word is mere flattery

31. A claim runs: 'Because Faxian praised Gupta charity, Gupta society must have been fair to all.' The flaw is that:

- (A) Faxian never mentioned any charity, so the premise is simply invented
- (B) Charity in cities does not prove fairness for all, and Faxian himself noted the exclusion of the chandalas
- (C) Charity always guarantees complete social equality everywhere
- (D) Faxian was actually a Gupta king and so cannot be trusted at all

32. How do a pilgrim's travel account and a king's prashasti differ most clearly as historical sources?

- (A) The pilgrim is an outside observer describing society he passed through, while the prashasti is composed to glorify a particular ruler
- (B) The prashasti is wholly unbiased while the pilgrim's account is pure fiction
- (C) Both were written by the same court poet for the same king
- (D) Neither can be used, because both are written documents

33. Faxian's praise of rest-houses and hospitals, set beside his note on the chandalas, teaches that a good historian should:

- (A) Keep only the cheerful details and discard the uncomfortable ones
- (B) Weigh the favourable and the troubling details together rather than seize on only one
- (C) Reject the entire account because it contains a single dark detail
- (D) Assume the whole account was forged because it is not wholly positive

34. A 'pilgrim' is best defined as a person who:

- (A) Travels to holy places, often to worship or gather sacred texts
- (B) Governs a kingdom temporarily for a child-monarch
- (C) Composes praise-poems celebrating the deeds of kings
- (D) Designs and mints the gold coinage of an empire

35. Aryabhata argued that the apparent daily turning of the stars is caused by the Earth's own rotation. Why was this remarkable for its time?

- (A) It explained the sky's nightly wheeling by the Earth spinning, rather than assuming the whole heavens revolve around a still Earth
- (B) It proved the Earth is flat and rests on a fixed pillar
- (C) It showed the Sun travels around the Earth once each year
- (D) It declared that the stars themselves physically race across India each night

36. The 'Aryabhatiya' is best described as:

- (A) A long praise-inscription celebrating Samudragupta's conquests
- (B) A Kalidasa play written for the Gupta court stage
- (C) A concise Sanskrit treatise gathering key results in mathematics and astronomy, from around 500 CE
- (D) A Buddhist monastery near the capital Pataliputra

37. Why is India's concept of shunya (zero) within a place-value system judged a world-changing contribution?

- (A) It made writing and calculating with very large numbers far simpler, and the system later spread across the world
- (B) It allowed Indians to stop using every other number entirely
- (C) It applied only to measuring the heights of temples
- (D) It was used once by Aryabhata and then forgotten for centuries

38. Why does the spread of the Indian decimal place-value system to other parts of the world matter for judging the Gupta age?

- (A) It proves the Guptas conquered all the lands that adopted the numerals
- (B) It shows the system was abandoned in India soon after it was invented
- (C) It means the numerals were only ever used for temple measurements
- (D) It shows that ideas born in this era had a lasting global influence well beyond India's borders

39. 'Astronomy', the science Aryabhata advanced, is:

- (A) The study and practice of traditional medicine
- (B) The art of carving stone sculptures
- (C) The writing of formal praise-poems for kings
- (D) The scientific study of the stars, planets and sky

40. Varahamihira is remembered for his encyclopedic work, the Brihat Samhita, which is best described as:

- (A) A praise-inscription celebrating Samudragupta's conquests
- (B) A love-themed play written for the Gupta court stage
- (C) A copper-plate record of a tax-free village grant
- (D) A broad compilation covering astronomy and a wide range of subjects

41. A student writes: 'Aryabhata forged the rust-resistant Iron Pillar after writing the Aryabhatiya.' Identify the mix-up.

- (A) There is no mix-up, since Aryabhata both wrote on astronomy and forged the pillar
- (B) The only error is the date, since Aryabhata did forge the pillar but in a later century
- (C) Aryabhata was a mathematician-astronomer who wrote the Aryabhatiya; the Iron Pillar is a metalwork marvel linked to a Gupta king, not to him
- (D) Aryabhata was a poet, so he wrote the pillar's praise-verses, which is correct

42. Kalidasa, a gem of the Gupta court, is best described as:

- (A) An astronomer who measured the motions of the planets
- (B) A poet and playwright, author of works such as the Meghadutam
- (C) An ironsmith who forged the rust-resistant pillar
- (D) A Chinese Buddhist pilgrim who toured India

43. That Kalidasa's plays are still performed about 1,500 years later is best taken as evidence that:

- (A) Gupta-age literature produced works of lasting artistic value that outlived the empire itself
- (B) The works must really have been written in modern times, not the Gupta age
- (C) Gupta culture cared only for science and never for the arts
- (D) Nothing made during the Gupta period managed to survive at all

44. 'Ayurveda', codified in this age, literally means the:

- (A) 'Sun of valour' (B) 'Science of life' (ayus + veda)
- (C) 'Great king of kings' (D) 'Science of the stars'

45. To 'codify' a body of knowledge such as Ayurveda means to:

- (A) Destroy the old texts so the knowledge is forgotten
- (B) Keep it a permanent secret known to one family only
- (C) Arrange and write it down in an organised, systematic form
- (D) Translate every word of it into the Greek language

46. The cave paintings of Ajanta, the carvings of Sarnath and the images of Udayagiri together belong to which strand of Gupta achievement?

- (A) Mathematics, as centres where zero was first written
- (B) Maritime trade, as ports exporting goods to Socotra
- (C) Royal minting, as workshops producing the empire's gold coins
- (D) Art and architecture, including painting and carved stone images

47. Garuda appears as a royal emblem and the vahana of Vishnu on Gupta symbols. This is best read as showing that the Guptas:

- (A) Worshipped only foreign Greek gods and rejected Indian ones
- (B) Ruled strictly as a Buddhist-only dynasty banning all other faiths
- (C) Had no interest in religion and used random animal pictures
- (D) Drew on Hindu religious imagery to express and sanctify their authority

48. Which conclusion about religious art in the Gupta era is best supported by the chapter's evidence?

- (A) Only Greek religious art was made anywhere in the empire
- (B) All religious art was banned outright by the Gupta rulers
- (C) Both Hindu imagery, such as Garuda and temple sculpture, and Buddhist art, such as the Ajanta paintings, were produced and patronised
- (D) Art in the period was confined entirely to mathematical diagrams

49. Indian merchants' graffiti found in a cave on Socotra, far out in the Indian Ocean, is best read as evidence that:

- (A) Indian traders of the period sailed and traded over long distances across the Indian Ocean
- (B) The Gupta empire had conquered and ruled the island of Socotra
- (C) Sailors from Socotra had invaded and settled in northern India
- (D) Socotra served as the Gupta capital instead of Pataliputra

50. Why do historians prize Gupta gold coins as a source even though their images are royal propaganda?

- (A) They are neutral records with no royal message, so they need no critical reading
- (B) They are useless, since anything a king issued must be entirely false
- (C) They are dateable physical objects revealing rulers, their imagery and the realm's wealth, even while their messages must be read critically
- (D) They matter only as raw gold and tell historians nothing about the rulers

51. Why did the Guptas issue abundant gold coinage rather than rely only on barter?

- (A) They had banned all trade and used coins only as temple offerings
- (B) A prosperous, trading economy needed reliable high-value currency, which the coins supplied while also broadcasting royal claims
- (C) Gold coins had replaced the need for any farming in the empire
- (D) The coins were purely ornamental and never used in exchange

52. Scholars travelled from distant lands to study at Nalanda. What does this tell us about Gupta-age India?

- (A) Learning in India was open only to foreigners and barred to locals
- (B) The Guptas had forbidden all study within their own borders
- (C) Its intellectual life drew students from far away, marking it as a hub of advanced learning with international reach
- (D) Nalanda was really a military fort rather than a place of study

53. When the Prayaga Prashasti, gold coins and overseas graffiti all point the same way about Gupta power and trade, this agreement is valuable because it:

- (A) Proves that a single source is always enough on its own
- (B) Shows that written inscriptions can now be safely ignored
- (C) Demonstrates that the Guptas kept no records of any kind
- (D) Lets historians cross-check different kinds of evidence, making the conclusion more trustworthy

54. The Gupta empire's decline in the 6th century CE is most directly linked to:

- (A) Repeated pressure and invasions by the Hunas entering through the northwest
- (B) A conquest of the north by the Pallavas of Kanchipuram
- (C) An invasion led by Roman legions from the west
- (D) The assassination of Chandragupta Maurya, leaving no heir

55. Why is it reasonable to treat the later Gupta period as a time of strain rather than uninterrupted glory?

- (A) The Guptas suddenly forgot all their mathematics and could no longer govern
- (B) A Roman army permanently occupied Pataliputra and ruled in their place
- (C) The Pallavas of the south absorbed the entire Gupta heartland in a single year
- (D) Mounting Huna invasions and the loss of revenue from repeated land grants steadily weakened the empire in its final century

56. The recurring entry of foreign groups such as the Hunas 'through the northwest' over many centuries suggests that region was:

- (A) A repeated gateway through which invaders and migrants entered the subcontinent
- (B) A region completely sealed off by impassable mountains
- (C) India's single richest stretch of farmland
- (D) The empire's main seaport for ocean trade

57. That the Pallavas in the south and Kamarupa in the northeast flourished at the same time as the Guptas leads to which conclusion?

- (A) The Guptas were the only kingdom anywhere in the whole of India
- (B) India was at that time ruled as a single province of China
- (C) The Guptas were a north-centred power sharing the subcontinent with other independent regional kingdoms
- (D) The Pallavas and Kamarupa were merely Gupta villages with no rulers of their own

58. The Pallava kingdom had its capital at Kanchipuram in the south while the Guptas ruled from Pataliputra in the north. This contrast underlines that:

- (A) The Pallavas were simply a branch office of the Gupta administration
- (B) Pataliputra and Kanchipuram were two names for the same city
- (C) The Guptas had moved their capital south to Kanchipuram
- (D) Distinct kingdoms with their own capitals coexisted in different regions of India in this era

59. To call the Gupta age a 'Golden Age' is accurate mainly about which aspect, and misleading about which?

- (A) Accurate about perfect equality and happiness for every subject
- (B) Accurate about its art, science, literature and trade, but misleading if read as social equality for everyone
- (C) Accurate about a complete absence of any conflict or hardship
- (D) Accurate about its total isolation from all outside contact

60. A student claims, 'The Gupta period proves science and art can flourish even while an empire is not perfectly fair.' The strongest evidence is that:

- (A) Every Gupta subject was treated equally and shared the wealth
- (B) Dazzling work by Aryabhata and Kalidasa coexisted with the harsh exclusion of the chandalas
- (C) The Guptas produced no science or art whatsoever
- (D) The Guptas governed with no titles and no administration

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 7: The Gupta Era: An Age of Tireless Creativity — Paper 4

Paper 4 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	B	11	B	21	D	31	B	41	C	51	B
2	C	12	B	22	C	32	A	42	B	52	C
3	B	13	B	23	D	33	B	43	A	53	D
4	C	14	A	24	C	34	A	44	B	54	A
5	A	15	C	25	A	35	A	45	C	55	D
6	A	16	D	26	C	36	C	46	D	56	A
7	D	17	D	27	B	37	A	47	D	57	C
8	A	18	A	28	D	38	D	48	C	58	D
9	C	19	B	29	C	39	D	49	A	59	B
10	A	20	D	30	B	40	D	50	C	60	B

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (B) The imperial line runs Chandragupta I, then his son Samudragupta, then Chandragupta II; so calling Chandragupta II the father of Samudragupta reverses the descent, making (iii) the false one. Statement (i) is true, since Chandragupta I is credited with first raising the Guptas to imperial status. Statement (ii) is true, as Samudragupta was indeed the son of Chandragupta I in the same Gupta dynasty. The claim that all three names mean one person is false, since they are three distinct rulers across successive reigns.

2. (C) The student's own timeline places the Kushanas in between, which proves a long interval rather than direct succession; the Guptas rose centuries later, around the 4th century CE. The Kushanas did not precede the Mauryas, so that correction misreads the order. The Guptas did not come before the Mauryas, who were the earlier empire. And

'after' need not mean 'immediately after', which is exactly the error of ignoring the gap the timeline itself displays.

3. (B) Sharing a capital city is a geographic continuity, not proof of one dynasty, so the fix is to keep the shared-capital fact while denying the identity claim. Kanchipuram was the Pallava southern capital, not a city both these dynasties used. Pallavas held Kanchipuram, not Pataliputra, so swapping in 'Pallava' is false. Pataliputra (present-day Patna) was an inland city on the Ganga plain, not a seaport, so calling it a seaport is wrong.

4. (C) Placing Samudragupta's campaigns in the 2nd century BCE drops them roughly six centuries before the Gupta age and echoes the classic confusion with the Mauryan era, so it clashes with the accepted dating. Huna pressure in the 6th century CE falls at the empire's close and fits the span. Chandragupta I in the early 4th century CE sits at the empire's rise and fits. Aryabhata around 500 CE lands inside the period, matching its scientific peak.

5. (A) Marrying into a respected established line gave the rising Guptas legitimacy and allies, the hallmark of a political marriage. A marriage is not a tax-collecting mechanism, so that option mistakes the institution. The alliance raised the Guptas rather than handing their throne to the Licchavis, so the surrender claim is false. Its clear political effect on prestige rules out 'purely religious with no bearing'.

6. (A) The Prayaga Prashasti praises Samudragupta the warrior king for his conquests, so that pairing is correct. The 'Chandra' Iron Pillar is linked to Chandragupta II, not Chandragupta I. The first to raise the Guptas to imperial status was Chandragupta I, not Chandragupta II. The Chinese pilgrim was Faxian, a traveller, not the Gupta king Kumaragupta.

7. (D) The Prayaga Prashasti is a praise-inscription of Samudragupta's conquests; Chandragupta II reigned afterwards and is remembered above all as a patron of arts and the conqueror of the Shakas, not as the inscription's subject. It glorifies one ruler, not two jointly, so the shared-credit option is false. The text was composed by the court poet Harisena, not by Chandragupta II himself. And it belongs to the Gupta age, not to the far earlier Maurya Chandragupta.

8. (A) Because the author served the king he praised, the eulogy is likely to exaggerate, so it should be used while being checked against coins, other inscriptions and accounts. Courtly authorship makes neutral acceptance unsafe, ruling out the first wrong option. The inscription is genuinely useful evidence when read critically, so dismissing it as worthless overcorrects. Harisena was the king's own poet, not a rival, so the secret-mockery option invents a hostile author.

9. (C) Harisena, Samudragupta's court poet, composed the Prayaga Prashasti recording the king's conquests. Kalidasa was a poet and dramatist, author of works such as the Meghadutam, not the prashasti's author. Aryabhata was a scientist who wrote the

Aryabhatiya, not court praise-poetry. Faxian was a Chinese Buddhist pilgrim and outside observer, not the king's eulogist.

10. (A) A reputation built on conquest implies he enlarged the realm he handed on, so the empire grew under him. Describing him as never waging war contradicts the very basis of his fame as a warrior king. The Aryabhatiya was Aryabhata's mathematical-astronomical treatise, unrelated to Samudragupta. And he was a Gupta ruler of the heartland, not a Central Asian invader, so that option confuses him with later Huna intruders.

11. (B) The deciding factor is the gap of centuries: the pillar's style and the 'Chandra' inscription belong to the Gupta age and Chandragupta II, not to the much earlier Maurya. The name 'Chandragupta' itself contains 'Chandra', so claiming the Maurya never used that element is false. The Mauryas worked iron and many metals, so the gold-only claim is wrong. Vikramaditya is a Gupta title, not one both kings shared, so that reasoning fails.

12. (B) Iron normally rusts readily, so the blanket statement is false; the marvel is the metallurgy, a passive layer formed by the phosphorus-rich iron. The column is genuinely iron, not bronze, so the bronze claim is wrong. Its protection is built into the metal's chemistry, not a yearly coat of paint. And the protection comes from the iron itself, not from being shielded from all rain.

13. (B) An iron column resisting rust for over a millennium is direct proof of sophisticated indigenous iron technology. It points to local skill, not to ready-made Roman imports. It plainly contradicts the idea that only gold could be worked. And it refutes any notion that iron-working was beyond ancient Indian smiths, since the pillar itself is the evidence.

14. (A) Taking the Shaka lands in the west gave the Guptas access to coastal trade toward the Arabian Sea, a strategic and commercial reward. The Guptas did not conquer China or reach the Pacific. Zero was a mathematical achievement of Indian scholars such as Aryabhata, not war booty. The Mauryas had fallen centuries before the Shakas, so the Shakas could not have been protecting them.

15. (C) Vikrama means valour and aditya means sun, so the title reads 'Sun of Valour'. 'Great king of kings' is the meaning of Maharajadhiraja, a different title. 'Universal ruler over lesser kings' is the sense of Chakravartin, again a separate term. 'Servant of the gods' matches none of the chapter's royal titles.

16. (D) A concentration of leading writers and scientists thriving under royal favour signals active patronage, the king funding and encouraging talent. A regent governs for another, which does not explain fostering scholars. A conqueror suppressing learning is the opposite of nurturing it. A pilgrim travels for religious ends and does not maintain a court of scholars, so that option misreads his role.

17. (D) Chandragupta II is associated with cultural splendour such as Kalidasa and with the 'Chandra' Iron Pillar, so that pairing is correct. The Prayaga Prashasti and the warrior-

conquest reputation belong to Samudragupta. The first founding of imperial greatness is credited to Chandragupta I. The Huna invasions belong to the later Gupta period, well after Chandragupta II.

18. (A) 'Great king of kings' asserts paramount status above other rulers, fitting an empire with subordinate kings beneath the emperor; a plain 'raja' claims only single kingship. A headman commands no kingdom, the opposite of an overlord's title. A ruler ceding power to a council does not crown himself 'king of kings'. And the title is royal, not priestly, so the priest option is false.

19. (B) Chakravartin expresses the ideal of a paramount, world-encompassing ruler standing above all other kings. A priest performs worship and is not a sovereign. A headman has only local authority, far below a universal ruler. An ambassador negotiates on a king's behalf and holds no sovereignty, so that option misplaces the role.

20. (D) The archer image signals military prowess and the 'king of kings' title signals supremacy, so together they present a powerful, paramount ruler. Humility with no claim to power contradicts both the warlike image and the lofty title. A throne-renouncing pilgrim is the reverse of a king advertising overlordship. A foreign gold-buyer fits neither the royal image nor the imperial title.

21. (D) Durable engraved grants prove the administration recorded who held land and on what terms, the mark of a documented bureaucracy. This contradicts any picture of purely oral rule. The grants record gifts to brahmins and temples, not ownership by foreign kings. And the grants are themselves written documents, so they do not show coins replacing writing.

22. (C) A tax-free grant means that land stops feeding revenue to the treasury and its holder gains local rights, so repeated grants quietly erode both income and central grip. Tax-free land by definition pays no tax, let alone double, so the treasury-swelling claim is self-contradictory. The grants did not determine who supplied soldiers, so the army-abolition option is invented. Overseas trade ran through merchants and ports independently of these land grants.

23. (D) The Guptas held the north and centre under direct rule but leaned on land grants and allied or tributary kings elsewhere, a looser arrangement than the Mauryan model. There was no yearly elected assembly choosing the king. No Roman officials administered Gupta provinces. And the emperor remained the supreme authority projecting power through grand titles, so total withdrawal is false.

24. (C) Gupta direct rule centred on the north and centre, while regions like the south (Pallavas) and northeast (Kamarupa) lay outside their control and grants and subordinate kings managed much of the rest. They governed far more than one city, so the single-city

claim is false. They had a strong central emperor, so the no-ruler claim is wrong. And they held real, large territory rather than being mere traders.

25. (A) Imposing titles advertised paramount status while a structured administration supplied the machinery to run a wide empire, so the two served authority and organisation. They did not mask a missing army, since the Guptas had military force. They did not declare the rulers foreign; the titles asserted Indian imperial kingship. And administration requires officials, so it could not aim to abolish their posts.

26. (C) Prabhavati Gupta married into the Vakatakas, a contemporary ruling dynasty linked to the Guptas by that alliance, and later acted as regent. The Hunas were invaders, not an allied house she joined. The Pallavas were a separate southern kingdom, not her marital dynasty. The Licchavis were the line Chandragupta I had married into, an earlier and different alliance.

27. (B) A regent rules temporarily for a monarch who cannot, such as a child heir, which is the role Prabhavati Gupta filled. Travelling to holy places defines a pilgrim, not a regent. Composing royal praise defines a court poet such as Harisena. Studying the heavens defines an astronomer such as Aryabhata, none of which is a regent.

28. (D) A Gupta princess ruling as regent and managing relations between kingdoms shows elite women could exercise genuine authority. That directly contradicts the claim that women were wholly barred from governance. She was an Indian princess, so the foreign-only condition is false. The sources credit her with administration and diplomacy, not with leading armies in battle.

29. (C) Faxian was a Chinese Buddhist pilgrim who came chiefly to visit sacred sites and collect texts, recording Gupta society on the way. The court poet who wrote the Prayaga Prashasti was Harisena, not Faxian. He was a pilgrim, not a Roman trader cataloguing ports. And he was a peaceful traveller, not a Huna military commander.

30. (B) Faxian saw mostly prosperous towns and pious institutions, yet his own account also reveals the harsh exclusion of the chandalas, showing prosperity was uneven, so one eyewitness gives a partial view to be checked. He was a contemporary traveller, not a writer centuries later. He genuinely journeyed through India rather than copying Roman traders. And he was an outside pilgrim, not a paid court flatterer.

31. (B) Visible urban charity does not establish equality across the whole of society, and Faxian's own report records the harsh exclusion of the chandalas, undercutting the conclusion. He did mention charity, so the premise is not invented. Charity does not by itself guarantee equality, so that option restates the very error. And Faxian was a pilgrim, not a king, so that distractor invents a false identity.

32. (A) A pilgrim records, as an outsider, the society he passes through, whereas a prashasti is purpose-built praise of one king and so shaped by a wish to flatter, making the

prashasti the more partial of the two. The prashasti is the biased one, not the neutral one, so the first option reverses the truth. The two had different authors and aims, so the same-poet claim is false. Both are usable when read with their purposes in mind, so dismissing both is wrong.

33. (B) A balanced reading uses both the positive and the disturbing observations to build a fuller, fairer picture. Cherry-picking the pleasant parts distorts the past. Discarding the whole source over one detail wastes good evidence. And mixed reporting actually argues for authenticity, not forgery, so the forgery assumption is unfounded.

34. (A) A pilgrim journeys to holy places, which is exactly why Faxian came to India to visit Buddhist sites. Governing for a child-king defines a regent. Composing royal praise defines a court poet. Designing coinage is the work of a mint or its craftsmen, none of which describes a pilgrim.

35. (A) Aryabhata's bold idea located the daily motion in the observer's spinning Earth rather than in a revolving cosmos. It was not a claim that the Earth is flat on a pillar. It was not a statement about the Sun's yearly path. And it was the opposite of saying the stars physically dash across the country; he attributed the appearance to the Earth's rotation.

36. (C) The Aryabhatiya is a short Sanskrit work compactly setting out major mathematical and astronomical findings of around 500 CE. It is not a royal eulogy like the Prayaga Prashasti. It is not a dramatic play like Kalidasa's. And it is a text, not a monastery, so the building option is false.

37. (A) Zero as a place-holder in a decimal system lets any quantity be written compactly and calculated efficiently, and the method eventually became standard arithmetic worldwide. It works with other numerals rather than replacing them all. It was a general calculating tool, not limited to temple measurement. And it was preserved and transmitted, not used once and forgotten.

38. (D) The worldwide adoption of the place-value system testifies to the deep, lasting impact of Gupta-age learning beyond India. The spread came through transmission of knowledge, not conquest, so the conquest claim is false. The system was kept and developed in India, not abandoned. And it served all kinds of calculation, not just temple measurement.

39. (D) Astronomy is the scientific study of celestial bodies and the sky, the field in which Aryabhata reasoned about the Earth's rotation. Traditional medicine is the domain of Ayurveda. Carving sculptures is art, exemplified at Sarnath. Writing royal praise is the work of a prashasti poet, not astronomy.

40. (D) The Brihat Samhita is a wide-ranging, encyclopedic text spanning astronomy and many fields, tied to the scholar Varahamihira. It is not a royal eulogy like the Prayaga

Prashasti. It is not a dramatic play like Kalidasa's. And it is a scholarly compilation, not a legal land-grant document.

41. (C) Aryabhata's domain was mathematics and astronomy, captured in the Aryabhataiya, while the Iron Pillar is a feat of metallurgy connected to a Gupta ruler, so fusing the two confuses a scholar with a monument. He was not an ironsmith, so the no-mix-up option is false. He never forged the pillar at any date, so the date-only correction fails. And he was a scientist, not the pillar's praise-poet.

42. (B) Kalidasa was a celebrated poet and dramatist whose works include the Meghadutam. Measuring planetary motion is the work of an astronomer such as Aryabhata. Forging iron is the craft of a metalworker, not a poet. And the touring pilgrim was Faxian, not Kalidasa.

43. (A) Continued performance across many centuries shows the court literature reached an enduring quality outlasting the political empire. Their long survival argues for their antiquity and excellence, not modern authorship. The flourishing of literature shows the era prized the arts, not only science. And these very texts are survivors, refuting the claim that nothing survived.

44. (B) Ayus means life and veda means knowledge or science, so Ayurveda is the 'science of life'. 'Sun of valour' is the meaning of the title Vikramaditya. 'Great king of kings' is the meaning of Maharajadhiraja. And the science of the stars would be astronomy, not Ayurveda.

45. (C) Codifying means setting knowledge out in an ordered, written, systematic way so it can be taught and preserved. It is not destruction, which would lose the knowledge. It is not secrecy, since systematic recording makes it shareable. And it is not specifically translation into Greek; the medical learning was given lasting written form in its own tradition.

46. (D) Ajanta's painted caves and the sculpture of Sarnath and Udayagiri are examples of the era's artistic and architectural flowering. They are not mathematical centres, since zero belongs to scholarship not these sites. They are not seaports exporting goods. And they are not mints producing coinage; their fame rests on art.

47. (D) Garuda, the mount of Vishnu, links Gupta kingship to Hindu devotional imagery, lending the rulers divine sanction. The Guptas did not adopt foreign Greek gods. They were not an exclusively Buddhist dynasty banning other faiths, as both Hindu and Buddhist art flourished. And Garuda was chosen deliberately for its religious meaning, not at random.

48. (C) The surviving works include Hindu royal emblems and temple sculpture alongside Buddhist cave paintings at Ajanta, showing patronage across traditions. There is no sign of an empire of only Greek art. Religious art clearly was not banned, since these very works

exist. And art was far broader than mathematical diagrams, spanning painting and sculpture.

49. (A) Traders leaving their marks on a distant island shows the long reach of Indian seaborne commerce, not political rule. There is no evidence the Guptas governed Socotra. The graffiti points to Indians travelling out, not islanders invading India. And the capital was Pataliputra far inland, not Socotra.

50. (C) Coins survive as concrete, often dateable artefacts that name rulers and display their claims and the realm's prosperity, so they are rich evidence even though the images are deliberate self-promotion. They are not message-free, so the neutral-record option is wrong. They are not worthless simply because a king made them. And they carry far more meaning than their metal value, so the raw-gold option fails.

51. (B) A flourishing economy with long-distance trade required dependable money, so the gold coinage served real commerce while also carrying the ruler's image and titles. Trade was thriving, not banned, so the temple-only claim is false. Coins did not displace farming, the economy's base. And they functioned as money in exchange, not as mere ornaments.

52. (C) Distant scholars converging on Nalanda show it was a renowned centre of higher learning whose reputation reached far beyond India. This does not mean local students were excluded; learning thrived at home too. It does not mean study was banned, which is the opposite of what its fame shows. And Nalanda was an educational institution, not a fortress.

53. (D) When independent sources of different types converge, each helps confirm the others, so the overall picture becomes more reliable. This is the opposite of trusting one source alone. It increases, not removes, the value of inscriptions. And it shows the Guptas kept abundant records, contradicting the no-records claim.

54. (A) The Hunas, coming from Central Asia through the northwest, wore down the later Guptas and hastened the empire's break-up. The Pallavas were a southern kingdom that did not conquer the north. No Roman legions invaded India. And Chandragupta Maurya belonged to a far earlier dynasty, so his death is irrelevant to the Gupta decline.

55. (D) The empire's last century combined Huna pressure from the northwest with the long-term drain of granting away revenue, so the period was one of decline. The empire did not lose its accumulated knowledge, so the forgetting claim is false. No Roman army occupied the capital. And the southern Pallavas did not swallow the Gupta heartland, so that option is invented.

56. (A) That successive outside groups kept arriving by the northwest marks it as a recurring overland entry point into India. It was clearly not sealed off, since people kept

coming through it. The description concerns the movement of peoples, not farmland fertility. And it was an overland route, not a seaport for ocean trade.

57. (C) Strong southern and northeastern kingdoms existing alongside the Guptas show the Guptas dominated the north and centre while other powers held their own regions. India was not a single Gupta realm. It was not a Chinese province. And the Pallavas and Kamarupa were full kingdoms with their own rulers, not Gupta villages.

58. (D) Two separate capitals in two regions show that independent kingdoms governed different parts of India simultaneously. The Pallavas were a sovereign southern dynasty, not a Gupta sub-office. The two cities were genuinely different places, not one city under two names. And the Guptas kept their capital at Pataliputra, never moving it to Kanchipuram.

59. (B) The label honours the era's cultural and scientific brilliance and its prosperous trade, but it does not describe social fairness, since groups such as the chandalas were excluded. There was no perfect equality, so that option is false. There was warfare and hardship, including the later invasions, so 'no conflict' is wrong. And India was well connected by trade, refuting any claim of total isolation.

60. (B) The claim is best proved by setting the era's brilliant achievements beside its real social injustice, exactly what the chandalas' exclusion alongside great science and art shows. Universal equality would undercut the argument's premise of unfairness. Denying any science or art is plainly false for this age. And the Guptas in fact had elaborate titles and administration, so that option is wrong.